

James Boswell

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James Boswell's enduring fame is as the biographer of Dr Johnson, but he is of great interest on his own account. He spent much time in and around Fleet Street, where he met with Dr Johnson and a wide circle of the leading literary figures of the day.

He was re-enrolled at Edinburgh and induced by his father to put his inheritance under trusteeship in return for an allowance of £100 a year. This was raised to £200 when he passed his oral law exam, allowing him to return to London.

Boswell had already started keeping his very idiosyncratic diary, in which he resolved to record everything. Conscious of his need for self-improvement, he tried to account for his bouts of melancholy. He recorded his sexual encounters, often accompanied by promises to reform, and many conversations verbatim. Both activities set him apart from most diarists.

Boswell practised law in Edinburgh for over a decade. He usually spent his annual break in London, meeting Johnson and many other writers, editors and printers. He finally moved to London in 1784 in the hope of improving his legal career, but had little success.

It is one of the lucky accidents of history that the Boswell papers were passed down from heir to heir, first in Scotland and then at Malahide Castle in Ireland, without being read because of their embarrassing reputation. In 1927, Ralph Isham, an American bibliophile, bought them.

Boswell first met Doctor Samuel Johnson on 16 May 1763. The journal before then describes his rather aimless life, seeking a commission in the Foot Guards, spending time with Scottish friends, and seeking sexual gratification with prostitutes or actresses.



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Boswell's London Journal was written daily from 15 November 1762 to 4 August 1763.

Thought by Mr Isham to have been lost, it was accidentally discovered in 1930 and added to the other Boswell papers. The Journal was written on loose quarto sheets, bundled up weekly and sent to a colleague to read.

Boswell married his cousin Margaret in 1769; they had four sons and three daughters. She remained faithful to him until her death in 1789, despite his frequent visits to prostitutes and repeated promises to reform.

One of Boswell's best-known books is his *Journal of a Tour to the Hebrides* with Samuel Johnson LL.D. The trip began

in Edinburgh in 1773, passing through St Andrews, Aberdeen, Inverness, Skye, Coll and Mull, before returning through Boswell's estate at Auchinleck.

Johnson published his account of the trip in 1775. Boswell's account appeared after Johnson's death in 1784. Both are still widely read; Boswell's is the more gossipy and succeeds because of his attention to detail.

It was a trailer for his *Life of Samuel Johnson*, which he prepared from the detailed diaries he kept throughout their friendship.

He attempted to stand for Parliament but failed to gain support, so concentrated on his *Life of Johnson*, published in 1791.

His health deteriorated due to excessive drinking and further bouts of venereal disease. He died in Great Portland Street, London, in 1795.

In 1949, Ralph Isham sold Boswell's papers to Yale University, which has published them ever since. Without this remarkable sequence of events, our knowledge of Boswell's life would have been very limited.